

(6) Pentecostalism (The Charismatic Movement)

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Pentecostalism is a movement that includes many different churches which places special importance on direct personal experience of God through the baptism of the Holy Spirit and charismatic gifts as described in the 'Books of Acts' in the Bible. When the distinguishing Pentecostal belief and practice entered (or adopted by) other mainline denominations (Methodist, Roman Catholic, Episcopalian, Baptist etc.) that was called 'the Charismatic Movement' which existed as a subculture within that denomination.

Churches based on Pentecostalism form a major Protestant denomination with approximately 100-130 million (2014 estimates) members (often called Pentecostals) worldwide. And approximately 300-350 million people (2014 estimates) identify themselves with the Charismatic Movement.

Pentecostalism began in 1901, when a student at Charles F. Parham's (perceived founder of the movement) Bethel Bible School in Topeka, Kansas, spoke in tongues (foreign language previously unknown to a specific individual). But the beginning of the widespread Pentecostal movement in the United States is generally considered to have begun with Parham's student William Seymour's (also considered as the founder) three-year-long Azusa Street Revival from 1906-1909.

Pentecostalism grew out of Methodism, Pietism, Millennialism and the Holiness movements of the 18th to early 20th century. From 1906 to 1909, a wide variety of Christians (black, white, and Hispanic, rich and poor), including some of the most prominent early leaders of the Pentecostal movement, traveled to Azusa Street Mission in Los Angeles, who sought the experience of the baptism of the Holy Spirit. Some of these individuals who were impacted went back to their communities and began their own Pentecostal churches. Soon Pentecostal churches sprang up across the United States, in rural areas as well in urban neighborhoods. Pentecostalism also made headways in the mid-twentieth century (1950-1970) in mainline denominations (Methodist, Roman Catholic, Episcopalian, Baptist etc.) as 'the Charismatic Movement', where believers instead of leaving their theology or churches/denominations stayed within.

Within Pentecostalism an early (in 1914 CE) dispute over the doctrine of the Trinity split the Pentecostalism into non-Trinitarian (Oneness Pentecostalism) and mainline Trinitarian denominations.

Today there are approximately 700 Pentecostal denominations and a large number of independent churches worldwide. And there is no one central authority governing all of them. Many Pentecostal denominations and churches are affiliated with the Pentecostal World Fellowship. Sometime it is difficult to know if a church/denomination is Pentecostal because many of them do not include the word 'Pentecostal' in their name. Some of the biggest and well known Pentecostals denominations are Assemblies of God, Apostolic Church (UK based), International Church of the Foursquare Gospel (ICFG), Church of God (Cleveland), The Pentecostal Mission and Church of God in Christ.

This movement flourished and growing in America where majority of the Pentecostals (approximately 25 million) live today. It is also growing in other parts of the world and large number of Pentecostals are found in Brazil (20 million), Guatemala (2.5 million), South Africa (5 million), Nigeria (11 million), and Kenya (12 million) to name a few (all population are estimates from various reports taken between 2010-2014).

Pentecostalism (with the exception of the Oneness movement, also known as Oneness

Pentecostalism, which does not accept the Trinity.), as a of Protestant denomination share the basic beliefs of most Protestant denominations.

In our following discussion we will focus only on unique aspects of Pentecostalism and where there are differences with other Protestant denominations. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Protestantism' in our website before proceeding any further.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Pentecostalism (like all other Protestant denominations)only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF (Only the unique features of Pentecostalism are discussed in this section)

The most distinguishing belief of Pentecostalism from that of other Protestant denominations is that it teaches Christians should seek the post conversion experience of Holy Spirit Baptism (i.e. a Holy Spirit filled life). Evidence of baptism with the Holy Spirit usually manifests in receiving one or more spiritual (charismatic) gifts such as speaking in tongues (unintelligible utterances or speaking a previously unknown language), interpreting tongues, ability to prophecy and healing the sick (gift of healing) etc.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

THE CHURCH

Most Pentecostal churches use congregational polity in which each individual church is fully independent and governed autonomously, free from the direct control or hierarchy of any other institution. Some also use Episcopal polity. Many are associated with national and international bodies.

~~The church structure is usually mostly devoid of statues and images.

THE CLERGY

There is no unified position on women in all levels of clergy. Some Pentecostal churches allow women in many level of church leadership, some allow restricted leadership roles and some do not allow any leadership roles.

~~Almost all mainline and traditional Pentecostal churches do not allow homosexual clergy.

THE ORDINANCES (OR SACRAMENTS)

Pentecostals commonly use the term ordinances in oppose to sacraments. And most usually accept Baptism and Holy Communion.

Baptism: Pentecostals do not baptize infants and little children. Most Pentecostal denominations practice believer's baptism by immersion. Pentecostals view water baptism as an outward symbol of one's conversion.

Holy Communion: Pentecostals believe that Holy Communion or Lord's Supper is symbolic and is to be used primarily to remind them of the sacrifice Jesus Christ made for them. Most Pentecostals use nonalcoholic wine or grape juice during communion instead of wine.

BAPTISM IN THE HOLY SPIRIT

Baptism in the Holy Spirit is the central belief of Pentecostalism, a teaching according to the first baptism in the Holy Spirit of the followers of Jesus Christ, on the day of Pentecost , as described in the second chapter of the Book of Acts in the Bible. Pentecostals believe baptism in the Holy Spirit is available to all Christians seeking to live a Holy Spirit filled life. Traditionally this is considered the second baptism that follows the usual water baptism (considered the first baptism).

Baptism in Holy Spirit is a distinct spiritual experience whereby Once a person is baptized feels himself totally immersed in the Holy Spirit which brings in the gifts of spirit. Most Pentecostals believe that the initial sign of the baptism in the Holy Spirit is speaking in tongues.

Speaking in Tongues: Initial and most common form of spiritual gifts. To Pentecostals Speaking in tongues mean speaking or utterances (with the power of Holy Spirit) miraculously in a language unknown to the speaker. This may be in the form of glossolalia which means unintelligible utterances (of no known human language) believed to be a divine language which may be interpreted by someone with the '**gift of interpretation**'. Speaking in tongues also can be in the form of xenoglossy which means a natural language (of human origin) previously unknown to the speaker.

Others spiritual gifts include ability of prophecy, ability to heal the sick, ability to perform miracles and ability to handle poisonous snakes etc.

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

Pentecostals take worship seriously as it is often viewed as an entryway for the baptism in the Holy Spirit. Their worship is less formal and more spontaneous and emotionally driven marked by speaking in tongues, clapping, chorusing, singing and dynamic preaching. Church services are often designed for the participants to worship freely with their body, heart and soul to bring about an atmosphere of god's presence.

SALVATION

Pentecostals believe falling away (loss of salvation) is possible.

STATUES AND IMAGES

There is very limited use of statues and images in Pentecostal churches.

CONTRACEPTION

Most Pentecostal churches allow responsible use of contraception.

ABORTION

Pentecostal Churches do not allow abortion except in case of 'life of mother'.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Most Pentecostal churches allow divorce and remarriage strictly only on biblical ground (adultery and abandonment or desertion by unbeliever spouse).

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Pentecostal>,
http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/christianity/subdivisions/pentecostal_1.shtml,
<http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Pentecostalism>,
http://ag.org/top/Beliefs/Our_Core_Doctrines/index.cfm#,
<http://www.cogic.org/cogic30/about-company/what-we-believe/>,

<http://www.churchofgod.org/beliefs/declaration-of-faith>.